country technology, military equipment, and economic opportunity. Indian officials had also contrasted US acquiescence to the French sale of nuclear reactors to China with its approach to the supply of nuclear fuel to India.[196] To reassure India, Carter wrote to Desai updating him on Deng's visit. The prime minister appreciated his assurance that the China normalization would not be at the expense of US-India relations or of other countries. But he worried that the enthusiastic reception that Deng received would complicate the US-Soviet détente process, which was a greater priority from Delhi's perspective. Speaking from India's own experience, he said that Moscow—sometimes "unnecessarily"—was "sensitive" to anyone "showing the least gesture" to China.[197]

India, on its part, soon made more than a little gesture toward China, with Vajpayee traveling there in mid-February for meetings with Deng, Hua Guofeng, and Huang Hua. A former Indian ambassador to China has called this visit "a turning point in the new opening."[198] At a banquet, Huang declared that China and India had broken the ice, and "we can now look forward to progress." Deng and Huang appreciated Desai's efforts to improve relations with India's neighbors. Vajpayee, in turn, emphasized that one could not forget history, but it was in the interest of both countries to establish a new relationship. India would remain prepared to defend itself if necessary but it would not hesitate to pursue peace. Alluding to both Moscow and Washington, he said, "Success in the effort to restore such a relationship can strengthen the fabric of peace in Asia. Failure can only be a comfort to those who want Asian nations to remain a plaything of international power politics." Finally, aware of Beijing's concerns about India's Soviet relationship, the Indian foreign minister stressed that Delhi would not try to take advantage of differences between countries and that India acted independently.[199]

Differences were evident on what to do about the boundary issue. Deng had told Indian journalists that China and India needed to set the border issue aside. Vajpayee, however, stressed to Hua and Deng that the border was fundamentally important, and talks were needed "sooner rather than later." He asserted that there was "no need to lose patience, nor should we try to push it aside or forget it." Overall, the talks ended on a positive note, with the two sides agreeing to maintain peace at the border and with Hua